

Q I want to have a baby. Should I just stop using birth control?

It depends on which type of birth control

you use. Condoms and spermicides can be stopped immediately. If you are on the pill or minipill, finish the course so you have a bleed. Although it may take a few months for ovulation to return to normal, you can conceive immediately after stopping without any risks to your baby.

If you have an IUD in place, or an implant, make an appointment for it to be removed. If you are on injections, simply stop renewing them and the hormones will gradually decrease. It can, however, take a year for your cycle to return to normal.

Whichever contraception you use, you may want to make diet and lifestyle changes and have medical checkups before you get pregnant. It may be worth doing this preconception preparation before you stop your birth control in case you become pregnant quickly.

Q Why should I have my immunity checked before conceiving?

Some infections are dangerous to catch in pregnancy, so it is wise to get your immunity checked before you conceive. Your doctor can arrange blood tests for this purpose. If you are not immune to certain infectious diseases, you can be vaccinated before you get pregnant, but not afterward. Rubella (German measles) is most dangerous to the fetus in the first 16 weeks, capable of causing miscarriage, stillbirth, or abnormalities such as hearing loss and brain damage. Chicken pox can cause miscarriage and birth defects. Vaccination prevents rubella and lessens the chance of getting chicken pox and makes it milder if you do contract it.

Hepatitis causes liver disease and can be passed to your baby; if you are at high risk of infection you should be immunized. Tests can also be done for group B streptococcus and chlamydia.

Toxoplasmosis is a parasitic infection that can be present in cat feces and undercooked meat. Avoid changing cat litter, and wash your hands thoroughly after gardening or handling raw meat. Wash all vegetables and fruit before eating. If you think you may be at risk of toxoplasmosis (see p.108), ask your doctor to test you.

Q Can we do anything to improve our chances of getting pregnant?

Improving your diet and lifestyle will put you in the best possible position to conceive—and that works for both of you. Sperm and egg cells both take three months to fully mature, so taking action early will produce the healthiest cells.

To be in the best shape for fertility and parenthood, remove unhealthy indulgences such as fast-food, refined carbohydrates, alcohol, caffeine, and tobacco from your life. Eat foods that



nourish you (see pp.48–55), and limit toxins by eating fresh, local, and organic produce if possible. Exercise to help maintain a healthy weight and to manage your stress levels.

TIPS FOR MALE FERTILITY

Improve the health of your sperm and be in the best shape for parenthood:



» **Take a multivitamin:** choose one that includes selenium, zinc, and folate for optimal sperm production and health.



» **Clean up your diet:** eat plenty of fruit and vegetables because their antioxidants promote sperm health.



» **Maintain a healthy weight:** too much or too little body weight can inhibit the production of reproductive hormones and affect sperm quality.



» **Quit smoking tobacco or marijuana:** both substances can affect fertility. Seek help to quit if necessary.



» **Limit alcohol:** too much can affect sperm quality.



» **Enjoy a caffeine boost:** there's nothing wrong with an occasional coffee.



» **Exercise moderately:** bicycling a lot could compress the testes, but bicycling in moderation is fine.



» **Reduce stress:** being stressed may affect certain hormones required for sperm production.

TIPS FOR FEMALE FERTILITY

Prevent hormone imbalances and help regulate your menstrual cycle:



» **Take folic acid:** take 400 mcg a day, either as a single supplement or as part of a preconception multivitamin.



» **Eat well:** make sure your diet is well balanced to maximize essential nutrients.



» **Maintain a healthy weight:** being overweight or underweight can affect fertility. Stay at a healthy weight by eating a balanced diet and exercising moderately.



» **Watch what you drink:** alcohol and caffeine can affect fertility. Your doctor will tell you to quit drinking alcoholic beverages to protect your baby, but if you don't want to give up coffee, that's okay. Limit your caffeine intake to 200 mg a day (about two cups of coffee). Remember, soft drinks, energy drinks, and tea also contain caffeine. Choose decaffeinated and fruit teas.



» **Quit smoking:** the toxins in cigarettes age your ovaries, damage your eggs, and adversely affect fertilization and implantation. Seek help to quit if necessary.



» **Manage stress:** find ways to relax. Try your best not to make getting pregnant your main focus.

Being **relaxed** can double your chances of becoming pregnant within a year—so **have fun and enjoy** trying to get pregnant!